US likely to escalate against Iran after midterms

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Hormuz attacks likely to compel US escalation after midterms

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An escalation of the conflict in which the US resumes kinetic strikes against Iran after the midterms is likely (65%, up from 35%), as US efforts to move oil through the Strait of Hormuz falter amid Iranian attacks.
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The US has various military options, ranging from large-scale bombing raids to more limited strikes against targets near the strait, though any resumption of strikes is likely to trigger Iranian retaliation and move oil prices into a higher range of $110-$125 per barrel.
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New strikes are unlikely to force more concessions from Iran, while the need to improve the unsustainable status quo may compel the US to agree to a limited deal (20%, up from 10%), though talks are currently making little progress.

The conflict is likely to escalate (65%, up from 35%). The standoff status quo is no longer sustainable for the US; talks remain deadlocked; and by early November, the US will have a considerable number of military assets in the region—including three aircraft carrier groups—that can support a return to active hostilities.

Despite the risks of escalation, a resumption of bombing is more attractive to US President Donald Trump than caving to Iranian demands or continuing the current, increasingly costly standoff.

Iranian aggression in the strait will compel US action. While the “wait and see” strategy was sustainable when flows were rising, its viability has deteriorated as Iranian attacks on shipping continue and energy prices remain stubbornly elevated (see: High oil prices to persist despite Hormuz progress , 5 October 2026).

Following several months of steady increases in regional energy flows, the US effort to escort ships out of the strait has stalled. Since 26 September, Iran has attacked more than two dozen ships and sunk two of them. Oil flows through Hormuz have fallen, from a high of 14 million barrels per day (bpd) to 10 million bpd according to preliminary data from Kpler. As Eurasia Group anticipated, the failure to maintain flows out of the region has increased pressure on the US to return to military action (see: Escalation risk ticks up as Trump ponders bombing after midterms , 7 October 2026).

The US is likely to wait until after the midterm elections on 3 November. The Trump administration wants to limit the impact that renewed strikes would have on the elections' outcome and give more time for assets to be moved into position.

The US ability to improve the status quo through force is limited. There are various options at Trump's disposal. They include large-scale strategic bombing raids on Iran's fortified missile and nuclear facilities, strikes on civilian infrastructure, and a more limited campaign consisting of strikes on Iranian assets in the Strait of Hormuz, similar to those the US carried out in August. Gulf Cooperation Council countries, whose leaders have influenced Trump's thinking before, are largely opposed to a return to military escalation. They will likely encourage more limited US military action given the anticipated Iranian response against them if the US pursues a more aggressive approach.

While rounds of bombing might temporarily blunt Iran's attacks on shipping, they are unlikely to accomplish the immediate US objective of restoring regional energy flows to the prewar status quo while bringing down energy prices. Iran is likely to retain the means to disrupt regional flows; military pressure is unlikely to force Iran to make new concessions.

Iran will retaliate against US bases and regional infrastructure. Iran's government has indicated to both the US and to regional states that any direct strikes are likely to prompt aggressive retaliation against US bases in the region as well as regional infrastructure. Iran's response will depend on the scope of US action. If US action is limited and focused on the strait, Iran's response is likely to be more calibrated and focused on US military assets, rather than more sensitive regional targets. It will continue to contest the strait with attacks on shipping.

Oil prices are likely to respond immediately to a resumption in fighting. Escalation is likely to drive oil prices into a higher band of $110-$125, for as long as the escalatory phase lasts—likely several weeks, if not longer. Shipping will remain disrupted, and Iranian attacks on export terminals, pipelines, refineries, or processing facilities will worsen the price impact.

A deal remains unlikely. The odds that a deal come together have slightly increased (20%, up from 10%) as the standoff becomes unsustainable for the US. Talks continue via mediators, though they have made little progress. Iran continues to make demands that the US finds unacceptable, while rejecting US demands for concessions on its nuclear program. Absent any material change in either side's negotiating position, a breakthrough remains unlikely.

Following escalation, the standoff will resume. In the likely event that bombing fails to extract new concessions from Iran, the US is likely to revert to a standoff posture once the strikes on Iran conclude, refocusing efforts on restoring flows through Hormuz. Iran, similarly, will pause its retaliatory strikes once US operations conclude, but will continue striking shipping and contesting the strait. Regional mediators are likely to be active in facilitating de-escalation and bringing the two sides back to the negotiating table, though these efforts are likely to proceed slowly.

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